



NATIONALISM IN INDIA

History - Class 10 | Chapter 2 | Clean Structured NCERT Notes

Complete, clean and board-ready notes with bigger readable font, clear hierarchy, proper spacing, and important words in bold.

1. Chapter Backbone - What You Must Understand

This chapter explains how Indian nationalism became a mass movement under **Mahatma Gandhi** after the **First World War**. It shows how different groups - peasants, workers, business people, **women**, **Dalits**, Muslims, students, tribals, plantation workers and revolutionaries - joined the freedom struggle with different hopes.

- The chapter begins with the impact of the **First World War** and the rise of popular anger against British rule.
- Gandhi introduced **Satyagraha** as a method of fighting injustice through truth, non-violence and self-suffering.
- The **Rowlatt Act**, **Jallianwala Bagh** massacre, Khilafat issue and **Non-Cooperation Movement** made nationalism a mass force.
- The **Civil Disobedience Movement** began with the **Salt March** and showed open defiance of British laws.
- The chapter also explains the limits of nationalism: different communities and classes did not always have the same demands.
- The final section shows how culture, symbols, songs, flags and **Bharat Mata** created a sense of **collective belonging**.

Core flow: War hardship -> Gandhi and **Satyagraha** -> **Rowlatt Act** -> **Jallianwala Bagh** -> Khilafat + Non-Cooperation -> local movements -> Civil Disobedience -> different social groups -> limits -> **collective belonging**.

2. The First World War and Its Impact on India

The **First World War** was fought between **1914** and **1918**. Although the war was mainly fought in Europe, it deeply affected India because India was under British colonial rule. Britain used Indian money, resources and soldiers for the war.

Economic impact

- Defence spending increased enormously because Britain needed money to fight the war.
- The British government raised taxes to finance the war effort.
- Income tax was introduced for the first time in India.
- Customs duties were increased, making many goods costlier.
- Prices of essential commodities doubled between 1913 and **1918**, making daily life difficult for ordinary people.
- Poor people, peasants and workers suffered the most because wages did not rise equally with prices.

Social and human impact

- Forced recruitment took place in many villages because Britain needed soldiers for the war.
- The population increased by about 13 million according to census records, increasing pressure on food and jobs.
- Crop failures in **1918-19** and **1920-21** created serious food shortages.
- Famine-like conditions spread in many regions because food grains became scarce and expensive.
- An **influenza epidemic** spread after the war, killing millions of people.
- Around 12 to 13 million people died due to famine and epidemic combined between **1918** and **1920**.

Political impact

- The British had promised constitutional reforms to Indians for their support during the war.
- After the war, instead of real freedom, the British introduced repressive laws like the **Rowlatt Act**.
- Indians felt cheated because their sacrifices were not respected.
- Indian soldiers who had fought abroad returned with new experiences and wider political awareness.

- The war exposed the contradiction between British claims of democracy and its colonial rule over India.

Exam logic: The **First World War** created economic hardship, political disappointment and mass anger. This prepared the ground for Gandhi-led mass movements.

3. The Idea of Satyagraha

Mahatma Gandhi returned to India from South Africa in January 1915. In South Africa, he had developed the method of **Satyagraha** while fighting racial discrimination against Indians.

Meaning of Satyagraha

- The word **Satyagraha** comes from **Satya**, meaning truth, and **Agraha**, meaning insistence or firmness.
- It means insistence on truth or **truth force**.
- It is not passive weakness; it is active moral resistance against injustice.
- A satyagrahi does not use violence against the oppressor.
- Instead, the satyagrahi accepts suffering voluntarily to awaken the conscience of the wrongdoer.
- Gandhi believed that if the cause was true and just, violence was unnecessary.

First Satyagraha movements in India

Place / Year	Issue	Result / Importance
Champaran, 1916	Indigo cultivators were forced by British planters to grow indigo and faced exploitation.	Gandhi organised peaceful protest; it proved Satyagraha could work in India.
Ahmedabad, 1918	Cotton mill workers demanded higher wages.	Gandhi supported workers and used fasting as moral pressure.
Kheda, 1918	Peasants could not pay revenue because of crop failure.	Gandhi supported peasants and demanded revenue relief.

Importance: These early struggles made Gandhi a national leader and showed that ordinary peasants and workers could be organised through non-violent mass action.

4. The Rowlatt Act and Jallianwala Bagh

In **1919**, the British passed the **Rowlatt Act** despite strong opposition from Indian leaders. Indians called it a black law because it attacked basic civil rights.

Features of the Rowlatt Act

- The government could arrest people without warrant.
- Political activists could be detained without trial.
- People could be imprisoned for up to two years without proper legal procedure.
- The Act gave the colonial state enormous power to repress nationalist activities.
- It proved that the British were not ready to give Indians real rights after the war.

Nationwide protest

- Gandhi launched a nationwide **Satyagraha** against the **Rowlatt Act**.
- A **hartal** was called on **6 April 1919**.
- Shops were closed, workers went on strike and processions were organised in many towns.
- The British responded with arrests and firing on protesters.
- In Amritsar, local leaders were arrested and public anger increased.

Jallianwala Bagh massacre

- On **13 April 1919**, a large crowd gathered at **Jallianwala Bagh** in Amritsar.
- Some people came to protest peacefully; many villagers had come for the Baisakhi fair and did not know about the **martial law** restrictions.
- **General Dyer** entered the enclosed ground with troops and blocked the exits.
- He ordered firing on the unarmed crowd without warning.
- Hundreds were killed and many more were wounded.
- The massacre shocked the whole nation and destroyed Indian faith in British justice.

Turning point: **Jallianwala Bagh** made many Indians realise that British rule was not reformable through petitions alone. National anger deepened.

5. The Khilafat Movement

After the **First World War**, the Ottoman Empire was defeated. The Ottoman Sultan was also the Caliph, the spiritual head of many Muslims. Indian Muslims feared that the position of the Caliph would be weakened or destroyed. This led to the **Khilafat Movement** in India.

- The **Khilafat Movement** began in **1919** to protect the authority of the Ottoman Caliph.
- It was led by the **Ali Brothers - Muhammad Ali and Shaukat Ali**.
- A Khilafat Committee was formed to organise protests and mobilise Indian Muslims.
- Gandhi saw the Khilafat issue as an opportunity to unite Hindus and Muslims in a common anti-British struggle.
- **Congress** supported the Khilafat demands and linked them with Non-Cooperation against the British.
- The movement brought many Muslims into the national movement and created a temporary Hindu-Muslim unity.

Exam logic: Gandhi supported Khilafat not only for religious sympathy but because it helped create a broad united national movement against colonial rule.

6. Non-Cooperation Movement, 1920-22

The **Non-Cooperation Movement** was adopted by the **Congress** at the **Nagpur session** in **December 1920**. Gandhi argued that British rule survived because Indians cooperated with it. If Indians refused to cooperate, British rule would collapse.

Main idea

- Non-cooperation meant refusing to support British institutions, honours, schools, courts, councils and goods.
- The aim was to achieve **Swaraj** or self-rule through peaceful mass action.
- The movement was connected with the Khilafat cause, making it broader and more powerful.

- Gandhi believed that **Swaraj** could be achieved within one year if Indians united and followed non-violence.

Programme of Non-Cooperation

- Surrender of titles, honours and awards given by the British.
- Boycott of civil services, army, police, courts and legislative councils.
- Boycott of government schools and colleges.
- Boycott of foreign goods, especially foreign cloth.
- Promotion of swadeshi, khadi and national education.
- Picketing of liquor shops and foreign cloth shops.
- If repression continued, civil disobedience would be launched in the final stage.

Spread and impact

- Students left government schools and colleges and joined national institutions.
- Lawyers such as Motilal Nehru and C.R. Das gave up legal practice in British courts.
- Foreign cloth was burnt in public bonfires.
- Khadi became a symbol of self-reliance and national pride.
- Liquor shops were picketed and social reform ideas spread.
- The movement made nationalism visible in everyday life.

Why the movement slowed down

- Khadi cloth was often more expensive than mill-made cloth, so poor people could not always afford it.
- Alternative Indian institutions were not enough to replace British schools and courts quickly.
- Some students and teachers returned to government schools.
- Some lawyers returned to courts.
- The movement required strict discipline and non-violence, which was difficult to maintain everywhere.

Chauri Chaura and withdrawal

- In **February 1922**, protesters at **Chauri Chaura** in Uttar Pradesh clashed with the police.
- A police station was burnt and **22 policemen** were killed.

- Gandhi was shocked by the violence and believed people were not ready for **Satyagraha**.
- He withdrew the **Non-Cooperation Movement**.
- Many leaders and young nationalists were disappointed because they wanted the struggle to continue.

7. Differing Strands Within the Non-Cooperation Movement

The **Non-Cooperation Movement** did not mean the same thing to every group. Different people joined the movement with different local grievances and expectations.

Peasants in Awadh

- In **Awadh**, peasants were led by **Baba Ramchandra**, a sanyasi who had earlier worked as an indentured labourer in Fiji.
- Peasants suffered under landlords who demanded high rents and many illegal cesses.
- They were forced to do **begar**, meaning unpaid forced labour.
- They demanded reduction of revenue, abolition of **begar** and social boycott of oppressive landlords.
- In 1920, the **Oudh Kisan Sabha** was set up by **Jawaharlal Nehru**, **Baba Ramchandra** and others.
- The peasant movement sometimes became more radical than **Congress** leaders expected.

Tribal peasants in Gudem Hills

- In the **Gudem Hills** of Andhra Pradesh, tribal peasants were angry because colonial forest laws restricted their access to forests.
- They could not collect fuel, graze cattle or practise shifting cultivation freely.
- Their livelihoods were damaged by colonial forest control.
- **Alluri Sitaram Raju** became the leader of the tribal revolt.
- He claimed special powers and inspired tribals to resist British rule.
- Unlike Gandhi, he believed India could be liberated by force and led guerrilla warfare.

- He was captured and executed in 1924, but became a folk hero.

Plantation workers in Assam

- Plantation workers were trapped in tea gardens under the **Inland Emigration Act** of 1859.
- They could not leave the plantations without permission.
- For them, **Swaraj** meant freedom to move and return to their villages.
- When they heard of the **Non-Cooperation Movement**, many workers left plantations and tried to go home.
- They believed **Gandhi Raj** was coming and land would be given to them in their villages.
- They were stopped by authorities, and many were caught on the way.

Important understanding: Nationalism became powerful because different groups connected Gandhi and **Swaraj** to their own local problems. But this also meant the movement had many meanings at once.

8. Remodelling the Congress

For a national movement to become successful, **Congress** had to become a mass organisation, not just a platform of educated elites. Gandhi wanted **Congress** to reach villages, towns and ordinary people.

- **Congress** was reorganised to create committees from village level to national level.
- Provincial **Congress** Committees were reorganised on linguistic lines to connect better with people.
- Membership fees were reduced so ordinary people could join.
- Local branches were created to spread nationalist ideas at the grassroots level.
- This made **Congress** more democratic, organised and mass-based.
- The change helped **Congress** mobilise people during Non-Cooperation and later Civil Disobedience.

9. Towards Civil Disobedience - Search for a New Programme

After the withdrawal of Non-Cooperation, nationalist politics entered a period of debate and reorganisation. Different groups inside the nationalist movement searched for new methods of struggle.

Swaraj Party

- Some leaders wanted to enter legislative councils and oppose British policies from within.
- C.R. Das and Motilal Nehru formed the **Swaraj** Party in 1923.
- They wanted to use councils to expose colonial rule and block government work.
- This was different from Gandhians who wanted constructive work outside councils.

Swing to the Left

- Many young leaders became impatient with slow constitutional politics.
- **Jawaharlal Nehru** and **Subhash Chandra Bose** supported more radical ideas.
- They were influenced by **socialism** and anti-imperialist movements worldwide.
- They wanted complete independence and social-economic transformation, not only political freedom.
- Workers and peasants began to be seen as important forces in the struggle.

Bhagat Singh and revolutionary nationalism

- **Bhagat Singh** became one of the most famous revolutionary figures of this period.
- He was associated with the **Hindustan Socialist Republican Association**.
- He believed that revolution meant not only ending British rule but also ending exploitation.
- In 1928, after Lala Lajpat Rai died due to police lathi charge, **Bhagat Singh** and his comrades killed Saunders, mistaking him for Scott.
- In 1929, **Bhagat Singh** and Batukeshwar Dutt threw bombs in the Central Legislative Assembly to make the deaf hear, not to kill people.
- **Bhagat Singh**, **Rajguru** and **Sukhdev** were hanged on **23 March 1931**, becoming martyrs for millions of Indians.

10. Lahore Congress and the Demand for Purna Swaraj

By the late 1920s, many nationalists were no longer satisfied with limited reforms. They wanted complete independence.

- The **Simon Commission** arrived in India in 1928 without a single Indian member, causing widespread protest.
- The slogan Simon Go Back became popular across India.
- In December 1929, the **Lahore Congress** session was held under the presidency of **Jawaharlal Nehru**.
- The demand for **Purna Swaraj**, or complete independence, was formally adopted.
- **26 January 1930** was celebrated as Independence Day by nationalists.
- This prepared the background for the **Civil Disobedience Movement**.

11. The Civil Disobedience Movement, 1930-34

Civil Disobedience was different from Non-Cooperation. In Non-Cooperation, people refused to cooperate with British institutions. In Civil Disobedience, people openly broke colonial laws and refused to obey unjust commands.

Why salt was chosen

- Salt was used by everyone - rich and poor, Hindu and Muslim, men and **women**.
- The British had monopoly over salt production and imposed tax on it.
- Gandhi believed the salt tax was the most oppressive face of British rule because it affected the poorest people.
- Salt gave the movement a simple symbol that every Indian could understand.

Dandi March

- On **12 March 1930**, Gandhi began the **Salt March** from Sabarmati Ashram to Dandi.
- He walked with 78 carefully chosen followers.
- The march covered about **240 miles** in 24 days.
- Thousands joined the route as Gandhi addressed people in villages and towns.
- On **6 April 1930**, Gandhi reached Dandi and broke the salt law by making salt from seawater.
- This marked the beginning of the **Civil Disobedience Movement**.

Forms of Civil Disobedience

- People made salt illegally in coastal areas.
- Foreign cloth was boycotted and burnt.
- Liquor shops were picketed.
- Peasants refused to pay revenue and chaukidari taxes in some regions.
- Village officials resigned in some places.
- Forest people violated forest laws by entering reserved forests to collect wood and graze cattle.
- Women joined processions, made salt and picketed shops in large numbers.

British repression

- The government arrested **Congress** leaders and activists.
- Gandhi was arrested in May 1930.
- Peaceful satyagrahis were beaten and thousands were jailed.
- Repression made the movement more visible and increased public anger.

Gandhi-Irwin Pact and Round Table Conference

- In 1931, Gandhi and Viceroy Lord Irwin signed the **Gandhi-Irwin Pact**.
- Gandhi agreed to attend the **Second Round Table Conference** in London.
- The government agreed to release many political prisoners and allow limited salt-making in coastal areas.
- The **Second Round Table Conference** failed because the British were not ready to give real power to Indians.
- Gandhi returned disappointed and restarted Civil Disobedience in 1932.
- The movement was finally withdrawn in **1934**.

12. How Different Groups Participated in Civil Disobedience

The **Civil Disobedience Movement** was a mass movement, but all groups did not join for the same reasons. Each group connected **Swaraj** with its own economic, social or political expectations.

Group	Why they joined	Limit / Problem
Rich peasants	They wanted reduction of revenue during the Great Depression and falling crop prices.	When the movement was called off, they were disappointed because revenue demands continued.
Poor peasants	They wanted unpaid rent to landlords to be remitted.	Congress did not fully support no-rent campaigns because it feared upsetting rich peasants and landlords.
Business class	They wanted protection against foreign imports and colonial economic restrictions.	They became hesitant when the movement became militant and workers raised labour demands.
Industrial workers	They wanted better wages and working conditions. Some joined strikes, especially in Nagpur.	Congress did not fully integrate workers because it wanted business support.
Women	They joined marches, made salt, picketed liquor and foreign cloth shops, and went to jail.	Congress still kept women mostly in symbolic roles and did not give equal leadership status.
Dalits	Some Dalit leaders focused on political rights and social equality rather than Congress nationalism.	They were often alienated because caste discrimination continued.
Muslims	Some joined, but many remained distant after the decline of Khilafat and rising communal tensions.	Fear of Hindu majority politics created mistrust between Congress and Muslim League .

13. Limits of Civil Disobedience

The **Civil Disobedience Movement** was powerful, but it also revealed the limits of Indian nationalism. The whole nation did not participate in the same way. Some communities and groups felt their specific concerns were not fully represented.

Dalits and Ambedkar

- **Dalits**, then called untouchables, faced severe social discrimination within Hindu society.
- Many Dalit leaders wanted political representation and social dignity before joining **Congress** movements fully.
- **Dr. B.R. Ambedkar** organised **Dalits** and demanded **separate electorates** to ensure independent political voice.

- Gandhi opposed **separate electorates** because he believed they would divide Hindu society.
- In 1932, the **Poona Pact** was signed between Gandhi and Ambedkar.
- The pact gave reserved seats to **Dalits** in provincial and central legislative councils, but within the general electorate.

Muslims and communal tension

- After the decline of the Khilafat and Non-Cooperation alliance, many Muslims became distant from **Congress**.
- Relations between **Congress** and the **Muslim League** worsened in the late 1920s.
- **Muhammad Ali Jinnah** demanded safeguards for Muslims, including **separate electorates**.
- Many Muslim leaders feared that Muslims would become a permanent minority in a Hindu-majority independent India.
- Communal tension and riots weakened the sense of national unity.

Final logic: Nationalism was strong, but not automatically united. Class, caste, religion and gender created different expectations from freedom.

14. The Sense of Collective Belonging

Nationalism does not grow only through political speeches. It also grows through symbols, songs, images, history, flags, stories and emotional imagination. These helped Indians feel that they belonged to one nation.

Bharat Mata

- The image of **Bharat Mata** made the nation appear as a mother figure.
- **Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay** wrote **Vande Mataram** as a hymn to the motherland.
- **Abanindranath Tagore** painted **Bharat Mata** as a calm, spiritual, saint-like figure.
- The image created emotional devotion to the nation.

Flags as symbols

- During the **Swadeshi Movement** in Bengal, a **tricolour flag** was designed with eight lotuses and a crescent moon.

- The eight lotuses represented eight provinces of British India.
- The crescent symbolised Hindu-Muslim unity.
- In 1921, Gandhi designed a swaraj flag with the spinning wheel at the centre.
- The spinning wheel symbolised self-help, dignity of labour and swadeshi.

Folk culture and history

- Nationalists collected folk songs, legends and stories from villages to show India had a rich cultural past.
- These cultural traditions helped ordinary people feel connected to the nation.
- History was rewritten to show India as glorious in ancient times, with achievements in art, science, literature, mathematics and philosophy.
- This helped Indians gain pride and confidence against colonial claims that India was backward.

Exam logic: Symbols like **Bharat Mata**, **Vande Mataram**, national flags, folk songs and historical memory helped create emotional unity among Indians.

15. Key Terms - Learn These Perfectly

Term	Meaning
Satyagraha	A method of struggle based on truth, non-violence and voluntary suffering.
Hartal	A strike where shops and workplaces are closed as protest.
Rowlatt Act	1919 law that allowed detention without trial and repression of political activity.
Khilafat Movement	Movement by Indian Muslims to protect the Ottoman Caliph after World War I.
Swaraj	Self-rule or freedom from colonial control.
Non-Cooperation	Refusal to cooperate with British institutions, titles, schools, courts and goods.
Civil Disobedience	Open violation of unjust colonial laws.
Purna Swaraj	Complete independence.
Poona Pact	1932 agreement between Gandhi and Ambedkar on reserved seats for Dalits .

Term	Meaning
Collective belonging	A shared feeling among people that they are part of one nation.

16. Timeline - One-Shot Revision

Year	Event
1914-1918	First World War.
1915	Mahatma Gandhi returned to India from South Africa.
1916	Champan Satyagraha.
1918	Ahmedabad and Kheda Satyagrahas.
1919	Rowlatt Act , nationwide hartal and Jallianwala Bagh massacre.
1919	Khilafat Movement began.
1920	Non-Cooperation adopted at Nagpur session .
1922	Chauri Chaura incident and withdrawal of Non-Cooperation.
1928	Simon Commission protests; Saunders killed after Lala Lajpat Rai death.
1929	Lahore Congress declared Purna Swaraj .
26 Jan 1930	Independence Day celebrated by nationalists.
12 Mar 1930	Dandi March began.
6 Apr 1930	Gandhi broke salt law at Dandi.
1931	Gandhi-Irwin Pact and Second Round Table Conference .
1932	Poona Pact .
1934	Civil Disobedience Movement withdrawn.